

Chapter 14 - Meeting Old Friends Again

Ning Fuyi immediately froze. She looked down at the "Chu Qingqiu" in front of her, then looked up at Chu Qingqiu at the door, and couldn't help but curse.

She naturally knew that immortals who had cultivated to a certain level mostly knew the art of body division¹, but this technique consumed mental energy and cultivation, so people only used it at critical moments. Who would have thought that Chu Qingqiu would be so careless, casually creating a spirit body to practice two copies when she had nothing to do.

"What are you doing?" Chu Qingqiu's gaze lingered on Ning Fuyi's hands.

"Making mischief." Since she had been discovered, Ning Fuyi didn't hide it either. She swaggered and clapped her hands, straightening her waist.

Chu Qingqiu hadn't expected her to answer so straightforwardly. Her words were momentarily stuck, and the atmosphere in the room fell into an eerie silence.

"Are you so unwilling to practice cultivation?" After a long while, Chu Qingqiu spoke again, her voice sounding as elusive as wind, impossible to tell if she was happy or angry.

"Unwilling." Since she had already been caught red-handed, Ning Fuyi was too lazy to beat around the bush. "This disciple is dull and incompetent, truly not cultivation material. Why should the Divine Venerable waste effort on me?"

"So you make mischief, hoping to make me give up on teaching you?"

"Yes." Ning Fuyi spoke with conviction, then lowered her head, tying the unfinished knot, and in front of Chu Qingqiu, transformed it into a bright red color.

Chu Qingqiu's hands clenched tighter, her complexion visibly darkening.

Ning Fuyi clearly felt the tremendous pressure on her shoulders. Although she appeared fearless on the surface, her heartbeat gradually quickened, and her back became damp, as if she had broken into a cold sweat.

Although she had been a demon lord and had tortured Chu Qingqiu plenty, she was currently only in a young girl's body after all. The fear she once felt facing the cold Divine Venerable could not be dispelled.

However, this tension didn't last long before she heard a whispered "Get out." Ning Fuyi immediately felt as if she had received a great pardon. Without even looking at Chu Qingqiu, she turned and leaped out the window, her black figure disappearing into the swaying tree shadows.

"Master!" A clear voice rang out. Qiu Yi had just appeared at the door when she was nearly frightened into falling by the appearance of the "Chu Qingqiu" on the couch. She quickly grabbed the door frame and became furious. "Besides that waste, who else could do such an outrageous thing? Master, don't worry - I'll quickly catch her and make her apologize to you!"

"Qiu Yi." Chu Qingqiu suddenly turned toward her, her gaze sharp as a knife, cutting Qiu Yi's words short so that she couldn't say anything more.

"I have said before, the word 'waste' is not to be used again," Chu Qingqiu said in a low voice.

"Master, please forgive me." Qiu Yi quickly covered her mouth and knelt on one knee. "This disciple simply couldn't bear to see you insulted, which is why..."

"Go down." Chu Qingqiu slightly closed her eyes, as if calming something, and her tone became gentler. "Don't let me hear such words again in the future."

"This disciple wouldn't dare." Qiu Yi was frightened into a cold sweat and no longer dared to say more. She got up and retreated outside the door, leaving only Chu Qingqiu alone in the room.

She slowly opened her eyes, her gaze falling on her own "body" again. Then she slowly approached, her fingertips stroking the two large red gardenias on her head. As if remembering something, besides looking serious, the corners of her mouth actually turned up slightly.

"What should I do with you?"

"Little demon," she murmured to herself.

Ning Fuyi thought her mischief-making method was effective. At least for the next two days, no one dragged her from her bed to that damned Tranquil Mountain Palace for morning cultivation. Presumably, Chu Qingqiu had finally recognized reality and given up on fulfilling Ning Changfeng's last words.

However, the next morning, when she was sneaking out of Pearl Light Pavilion² like a thief, she found those papers filled with heart formulas at the door. The papers had been bound into a book, with familiar elegant handwriting providing detailed annotations by category.

After opening the book, Ning Fuyi suddenly felt a strange emotion, but it passed in an instant.

Her face was thicker than a city wall - how could she feel guilty toward Chu Qingqiu? It must be an illusion, Ning Fuyi concluded.

Ning Fuyi's life returned to its former tranquility. She continued secretly studying demonic arts, and during daily immortal instruction, she also practiced Water system heart formulas. However, as she knew in her heart, being naturally slow, it had no effect.

Fortunately, she didn't care.

On this day, the weather was fine. Ning Fuyi walked through the gates of Suspended Beam Garden³ as usual, but found today was somewhat different. The disciples who usually waited inside the North Courtyard were all crowded in the open space at the entrance, chattering about something.

"Yiyi!" A soft call came from behind. Ning Fuyi turned around and saw Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin running toward her one after the other. Liu Wenzhu was holding a stone lion that was eight feet tall⁴, and disciples along the way made way for her in terror.

"Sorry, sorry..." Liu Wenzhu apologized all the way before stopping in front of Ning Fuyi, gently setting down the stone lion with a thud that made even the floor tiles shake.

Even though Ning Fuyi was used to such scenes, she still opened her mouth to express her shock.

"This is..." Ning Fuyi fanned away the dust near her nose, pointing at the stone lion that was two heads taller than her.

"Elder Yuanming asked me to move it here, saying it should be placed in the North Courtyard." Liu Wenzhu had a light tea-colored silk flower in her hair and not a single drop of sweat on her cheeks as she smiled gently. "What's happening today? Why is everyone standing here?"

Rong Jin, who arrived afterward, walked around the stone lion and answered: "I just heard the news. Several senior brothers and sisters from the East Courtyard hunted many high-level spirit beasts while training in Tongchuan⁵. Thinking that most North Courtyard disciples don't have contracted spirit pets yet, they asked everyone to take a look. If anyone encounters a compatible one, they can form a contract on the spot."

Upon hearing the words "spirit beasts," Liu Wenzhu's already crystal-clear eyes brightened even more. She reached down to grab Ning Fuyi's sleeve and whispered: "Yiyi, I've been longing to have my own spirit beast. That way, when traveling far in the future, it would be convenient and I wouldn't have to fly on swords every time, exhausting myself half to death."

Ning Fuyi smiled and nodded, not having the heart to tell her that her future spirit beast would be a divine mountain hedgehog⁶, and she'd still have to fly on swords when necessary.

"Come with me." Liu Wenzhu shook Ning Fuyi's sleeve. "Although Tongchuan is dangerous, with senior brothers and sisters and elders accompanying us, nothing will go wrong. Besides, I and Senior Brother Rong Jin will be there too."

"Alright." Ning Fuyi replied.

Ning Fuyi naturally wouldn't refuse Liu Wenzhu's request. Moreover, Tongchuan was located at the border of the Eastern Wasteland⁷. Beyond the Eastern Wasteland, demons and evil spirits ran rampant - it was a barbarous territory that cultivators traditionally wouldn't set foot in. Therefore, Tongchuan was full of dragon pools and tiger dens⁸ with dangerous situations everywhere. There were many spirit beasts, but also countless demon beasts.

Most importantly, in her previous life, after becoming a demon, she had tamed a demon beast called the Crimson Serpent Bird⁹ in Tongchuan.

So she wanted to try her luck.

While they were talking here, several tall male and female figures walked over from the other side, wearing the blue and white robes of the East Courtyard, with golden leather around their waists and various divine weapons¹⁰ in their hands. Compared to the North Courtyard disciples, they looked much more spirited at first glance.

Most East Courtyard disciples had broken through to the second level of Immortal Body Realm¹¹ and generally no longer received immortal instruction, instead traveling and training everywhere. Therefore, compared to the North Courtyard disciples, they appeared much more composed.

After they approached, the clustered disciples quickly turned toward them and bowed their heads in salute.

"You must already know about today's matter. However, Tongchuan is dangerous, so those who don't wish to go can stay here and cultivate on their own." The leader was the tallest man with a square face and a rough voice. "Disciples who are willing to go, please board the Flying Eagle Boat¹² outside."

Cheers arose from the crowd. What cultivator didn't long for spirit beasts? So no one stayed behind. All one hundred and eighty North Courtyard disciples boarded the Flying Eagle Boat. Besides several East Courtyard disciples at the second level of Immortal Body Realm, the group also included Perfected Being Yuanming, Elder Yuanming, who always loved to travel.

The Flying Eagle Boat was shaped as its name suggested, like a light boat with a head resembling an eagle's beak, majestic and imposing. Its size could change according to how many people were riding, making it Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's commonly used mount for long-distance travel.

The boat floated through the clouds, and in the blink of an eye, they had passed countless mountains. Ning Fuyi sat at the stern, watching the scenery below unfold like a painting amidst steaming clouds and rosy mists.

This was the first time she had left Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate since her rebirth, seeing these mountains, rivers, and seas that she had grown tired of walking alone in the past.

The journey to Tongchuan was truly too long. Even the Flying Eagle Boat, which could travel eight thousand li per day¹³, couldn't reach it in a single day. Since Tongchuan was extremely dangerous at night, the group didn't go directly there. Instead, when the sun was setting in the west, they landed outside Furong Town¹⁴, the closest town to Tongchuan.

Furong Town was a frontier settlement where mortals could hardly live, so the streets were full of traveling cultivators, as well as beast hunters and gold miners from the surrounding mountains, wearing strange clothes and selling spirit beasts and rare treasures. It was quite unique and lively.

The hundred-person group from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate walking among these strangely dressed people seemed very out of place. However, most North Courtyard disciples had never traveled far, so seeing so many novel things, they inevitably became excited and chatty.

"Tonight we'll rest at the largest inn, Azalea Tower¹⁵. Stay close together and don't get separated!" Rong Jin walked at the back of the group, loudly scolding disciples who were trying to slip away.

"Oh my, Rong Jin, just let them play for a while. It's rare for the children to see the world. In the future, the sky is high and birds can fly freely¹⁶ - you can't always keep them caged in Cloud Ascension Mountain like house sparrows." Elder Yuanming walked with his hands behind his back, smiling.

"Elder, this is improper. This place is a mixed bag of good and bad people, and it's not under the jurisdiction of the Four Great Families or Six Great Sects¹⁷. If there's danger..."

"Although this place is a mixed bag, looking around, how many have high cultivation? With this elder here, what trouble could arise?" Elder Yuanming waved his hand, blocking Rong Jin who wanted to go forward and bring people back.

"They all carry communication tokens¹⁸. When the time comes, just use the communication tokens to call them back." Elder Yuanming casually patted Rong Jin's shoulder. "Come, young man, this way."

Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu walked properly in front together. When they looked back again, the originally mighty procession had only a few people left.

Liu Wenzhu immediately became somewhat panicked, nervously grasping Ning Fuyi's hand: "Yiyi, we seem to have gotten separated. Where are Elder Yuanming and Senior Brother Rong Jin?"

Hearing this, Ning Fuyi was about to take out her communication token to inquire when she lowered her head and a familiar white shadow flashed before her eyes.

She suddenly stopped her actions, looking up in disbelief, her heart feeling as if someone had squeezed it, burning with pain.

Footnotes:

¹ Art of body division (分体之术) - A high-level cultivation technique allowing practitioners to create spirit duplicates of themselves

² Pearl Light Pavilion (珠光阁) - The female disciples' dormitory building

³ Suspended Beam Garden (悬梁苑) - A location within the sect for instruction

⁴ Eight feet tall (八尺高) - Traditional Chinese measurement; approximately 8-10 feet in modern terms

⁵ Tongchuan (铜川) - A dangerous region at the border of the Eastern Wasteland

⁶ Divine mountain hedgehog - Liu Wenzhu's destined spirit beast from Ning Fuyi's previous life memories

⁷ Eastern Wasteland (东荒) - A dangerous region beyond civilized cultivation territories

- ⁸ Dragon pools and tiger dens (龙潭虎穴) - Chinese idiom meaning extremely dangerous places
- ⁹ Crimson Serpent Bird (赤练鸟) - A demon beast Ning Fuyi tamed in her previous life
- ¹⁰ Divine weapons (神武) - Magical weapons used by cultivators
- ¹¹ Immortal Body Realm (仙身) - The sixth level in the cultivation hierarchy
- ¹² Flying Eagle Boat (飞鹰舟) - A flying vessel shaped like an eagle
- ¹³ Eight thousand li per day (一日八千里) - Li is a traditional Chinese distance unit; this represents extremely fast travel
- ¹⁴ Furong Town (芙蓉镇) - A frontier town near Tongchuan
- ¹⁵ Azalea Tower (杜鹃楼) - The largest inn in Furong Town
- ¹⁶ The sky is high and birds can fly freely (天高任鸟飞) - Chinese idiom meaning having freedom to pursue one's ambitions
- ¹⁷ Four Great Families and Six Great Sects (四大世家和六大门派) - Major power structures in the cultivation world
- ¹⁸ Communication tokens (传音牌) - Magical devices for long-distance communication